found too heavy to use. Akbar offered him some chainmail from his own armoury, and gave the heavy breastplate to another soldier called Karan, grandson of Jodhpur's Maldeo who had so troubled Akbar's father in the desert. Karan had come to battle without any armour at all, and would clearly benefit from a breastplate.

It was a neat solution that fell apart, however, when Jaimal's father, Rupsi, discovered the exchange. Rupsi, it now transpired, loved his hefty breastplate almost as much as he hated the house of Maldeo. Enraged, he sent a man to Akbar demanding his armour back. When Akbar refused – 'Your remark is not courteous'[48] – Rupsi threw off his own armour, declaring that he would rather go into battle unprotected than dispossessed. Never to be outdone, Akbar took off his armour, too.

The escalating conflict might have ended with yet another blade upon the royal tummy had Bhagwant Das not intervened, speaking firmly to Rupsi and telling Akbar that the Rajput was high on bhang.

'From there,' writes Abul Fazl, relieved, 'he moved forward in proper order.'

~

'Ya Mu'in!'[49]

Akbar's favourite battle cry at this time called upon Moinuddin Chishti of Ajmer, whose dargah Akbar had taken to visiting before and after any important enterprise. This time, too, in his mad rush to Ahmedabad, Akbar had stopped in Ajmer for the Sufi saint's blessing.

God knows, Akbar needed whatever help he could get. He was greatly outnumbered by the foe, whose army included a coalition of Gujaratis and Abyssinians;[50] Afghans under the Fuladis; and, of course, discontented Central Asian followers of the Mirzas. Akbar, meanwhile, had come without the bulk of his army – which could hardly have travelled so fast, and was exhausted, in any case, from the previous year's campaign. Besides, Akbar had planned that Aziz, besieged in Ahmedabad with his troops, would join Akbar in battle. Much like Muhammad Husain, however, Aziz just couldn't believe that Akbar had arrived so quickly – he thought the news was a trick to get him out of the fort, and so he stayed put.

As at Sarnal, Akbar's outnumbered troops were reluctant to wage war;